

THE UNIVERSAL HOUSE OF JUSTICE

5 March 2017

To all National Spiritual Assemblies

Dear Bahá'í Friends,

As you know from the message dated 19 May 2016 to all National Spiritual Assemblies from the Universal House of Justice, new members of the International Board of Trustees of Ḥuqúqu'lláh were appointed last year. Shortly after their appointment, the members of the International Board convened their first meeting at the Bahá'í World Centre. Given the significance of this gathering in the Holy Land and of the letter addressed to the International Board by the House of Justice on that occasion, we have been asked to share with you the enclosed extract from that letter. For your information, all Boards of Trustees of Ḥuqúqu'lláh have also received this same extract from that letter.

With loving Bahá'í greetings,

Department of the Secretariat

Extract from a letter dated 21 June 2016 from the Universal House of Justice to the International Board of Trustees of Ḥuqúqu'lláh

It is with great joy that we welcome you, the newly appointed members of the International Board of Trustees of Ḥuqúqu'lláh, to the Holy Land for your initial meeting. The opening of the current term of the Board marks a significant juncture in the evolution of the institution of Ḥuqúqu'lláh—an institution founded by Bahá'u'lláh Himself. We offer our gratitude to Him for the profound impact that obedience to this law has thus far had on the worldwide activities of the Bahá'í community, an impact which portends far-reaching implications for the transformation of society. As you gather to consult on the responsibilities that lie before you as Trustees of the Right of God, we call upon you to turn your attention to a few areas of fundamental importance to the further development of this institution.

In ordaining the mighty law of Ḥuqúqu'lláh, the Blessed Beauty has vouchsafed a favour unto His ardent lovers through which they can express their personal sense of devotion to God in a profoundly private act of conscience. This sacred law creates a direct and vital link between the individual believer and the Head of the Faith, enables the friends to become firm and steadfast, and, as the beloved Master affirms, exerts “a great influence on their hearts and souls”. Above all, when those privileged to pay the Right of God offer it in a spirit of joy, fellowship, and contentment, it will impart prosperity and protection, purify their worldly possessions, and enable them and their offspring to benefit from the fruits of their endeavours. Beyond the bestowal of such spiritual benefits upon the individual, this law promotes the common good and contributes to the spiritualization of humanity through the promotion of a new attitude towards the acquisition and use of material resources necessary for great collective enterprises designed to improve all aspects of life. Indeed, the institution of Ḥuqúqu'lláh is a key instrument for constructing the foundation and supporting the structure of the New World Order of Bahá'u'lláh, serving as a powerful element in the growth of a world civilization.

It is essential, then, that the spiritual significance of this mighty law, both in its individual and its social dimensions, remain uppermost in the minds of those serving the institution of the Right of God. In carrying out the vital functions they have been summoned to perform,

the members of the Regional and National Boards of Trustees share in the responsibility of ensuring that the institution of Ḥuqúqu'lláh is distinguished by the impeccable probity with which it is administered and that the believers' understanding of the spiritual and practical aspects of the law deepens. Naturally, the ways in which the Boards have conducted their work have evolved over the years; as you consider the greater demands that will be placed upon them, you are encouraged to examine how their current mode of functioning could be enhanced. The effective execution of their growing responsibilities will require the Boards to approach their duties in the same spirit of learning that characterizes the endeavours of the friends in the pursuit of every aspect of the Five Year Plan. No doubt, efforts to enhance the operation of the Boards will have an impact on the way in which they select, appoint, and orient Representatives and, more importantly, on how they nurture these friends and interact with them on a regular basis. In pursuing this work, it should also be recognized that the Continental Counsellors and National Spiritual Assemblies play a part in supporting this institution as they, too, endeavour to assist believers to uphold the laws of Bahá'u'lláh. Thus, it is of paramount importance that the members of the Boards continue to foster loving relationships with the Counsellors and their deputies as well as with National Assemblies. To this end, the Boards should be encouraged to consult with these two institutions when necessary on matters relating to Ḥuqúqu'lláh—particularly the various dimensions involved in the education of the believers in the law.

As those serving this institution strive to cultivate in the hearts of the believers a deep love and appreciation for this divine law, they will no doubt realize that the success of their efforts largely depends on the extent to which loving and trusting relationships are fostered between them and the believers. It is love for Bahá'u'lláh which will be the primary motive for the friends in obeying this law, but they will carry out their duty with greater assurance and promptitude the greater their confidence in those on whom has been conferred the responsibility of receiving the Right of God. In performing their spiritual task of drawing the attention of the friends to their obligations as Bahá'ís, Deputies and Representatives must act with utmost sensitivity and discretion so that believers never feel pressured to adhere to a law which is to be offered joyfully and without hesitation. Raising consciousness among different segments of a Bahá'í community requires a nuanced approach, owing to varying needs and circumstances. For example, young people who are at the early stages of earning a livelihood could be assisted to cultivate the habits and take on the perspectives that this sacred law promotes and to avail themselves of the bounties that obedience to it bestows throughout every phase of a fruitful and consecrated life.

In the discharge of your weighty duties, a number of legal and fiscal issues relating to the custodianship of Ḥuqúqu'lláh funds will require your ongoing attention, particularly given the new financial regulations being implemented in many parts of the world. Among these matters are ensuring that the processes and systems that the 31 Regional and National Boards have in place for receipting, holding, and remitting the funds are operating in an efficient and wise manner and that accurate and timely records are being maintained.

[signed: The Universal House of Justice]